her way around the city, and the coffee shop was in the vicinity. Twilight had set in, but we still had an hour to go. ‘It feels good to wear these kurtis after four long days,’ I said, to which Hema added, ‘I couldn’t agree more.’

‘We’ve gotten bored of our uniforms in four days! Imagine wearing them for a full decade,’ I said. ‘If we make it through SSB, that will be our fate.’

‘I hadn’t thought of that before,’ Hema exclaimed.

‘I’ve seen my father spend his entire life following the dress code of the army—getting out of the PT dress in the morning only to get into uniform, wearing the ceremonial uniform and formals for the mess functions and dinner nights and so on,’ I added.

‘But wearing casuals is a choice, wearing a uniform is a hard-earned privilege, right?’ Hema said.

‘And I’d choose such a privilege over and over again,’ I said. We had reached the coffee shop. It was nothing fancy, just a shop with cement walls and narrow wooden tables and stools. Two teenage boys wearing vests and dhotis ran from table to table, taking orders. The aroma of roasted coffee beans was enchanting. I took a whiff before we occupied a table.

‘Two cups of coffee, please,’ Hema said, and one of the boys responded with a nod. Her gaze followed the young boy as he ran inside the kitchen to get our order.

‘They remind me of my brother,’ she said to me with a reminiscing smile.

‘How so?’ I asked.

‘Well, let’s just say not all of us are privileged enough,’ Hema recounted. ‘I come from a family that has seen a lot of struggle. I’ve seen my Appa wake up every morning and go to work before any of us were awake, only to come back in the night, when we would already be in bed. I’ve seen my Amma work hard at home, as well as at her workplace. I’ve seen them sacrificing their needs to tend to their children’s demands. As we grew up, our expenses increased. Good education is always costly. So my brother would pick up petty jobs at shops to contribute to our family’s finances.’ She paused to greet the boy with a smile when the coffee arrived, and then continued, ‘I just want to make my family proud.’